EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

The Music of a Balanced Life

Emunot VeDeot, Essay 10:18-19

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 10 (How a Person Should Conduct Himself in This World), Chapters 18 and 19, the end of the sefer

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 12 January 2026, in person at Tiferet Hall and on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Recap: The Thirteen and the Harmony

Tonight the class finished the sefer, with a small celebration. Next week would be a shiur on the key takeaways of the whole book, and tonight the Rabbi also wanted to discuss options for the next sefer.

Throughout the tenth essay Saadia has taught the importance of balance. He went through thirteen activities that people pursue to the exclusion of everything else:

1. Abstinence
2. Eating and drinking
3. Intimacy
4. Passion
5. Accumulating wealth
6. Having many children
7. Work and developing one's career
8. Long life
9. Authority and power
10. Vengeance
11. The pursuit of intellect and wisdom
12. Serving Hashem alone
13. Rest

In Chapter 17, last week, Saadia concluded that each of the thirteen has its place, "even vengeance, for example, where you need to stand up and take revenge, in inverted commas, when someone's done something wrong." The good life balances all thirteen and takes a bit from each when it is needed. Not necessarily in equal measure: sometimes one is more appropriate than another. But a life in harmony, never taking anything to the extreme, as the Rambam later echoed.

Chapter 18 shows that harmony is not only a principle for character. "Harmony is a principle in all facets of life," and Saadia goes into great detail. "We're going to need a bit of help with the English here in Chapter

18, and if anyone's musical here, help as well."

Chapter 18: The Harmony of the Senses

וראיתי לנדב בסוף המאמר הזה בזכרון מזגי המוחשים... להיותו תוספת בסדר ובבחינה למה שהקדמנו ממזג המדות

At the end of the essay Saadia wants to discuss how the senses are blended, because it will help us understand what he has said about blending the traits of character.

There are five senses: taste, sight, hearing, smell and touch. He will not dwell on two of them:

- **Touch** gives pleasure in only one way: what is soft. "There's not much to discuss about that."
- **Taste** is also clear: it is known that a mixture gives the best flavour. Saadia's example is a dish called *faludaj*. The Rabbi noted that Rosenblatt's English translation does not translate the word; it seems to be a kind of sweet porridge, here made of starch, sugar and saffron. So too every mixed dish and cooked food. One ingredient on its own may taste good, but combining ingredients gives the best taste.

He goes through the other three: sight, hearing and smell.

Sight: colours

ואומר כי המראה הנפרד מלבן או אודם או ירוק או שחור, מנהגו להחליש החוש כשיביט בו

A single colour on its own, white or red or green or black, tends to weaken the sense when one stares at it, as the eye is struck by gazing at **snow**. Red can harm the eye, and black weakens the power of sight.

The Rabbi: "I didn't know, but there's actually a condition." Snow blindness is a real medical condition, **photokeratitis**, caused by exposure of the eyes to ultraviolet rays. "So the point he's saying is that... staring at one thing alone without a combination isn't good for you."

Besides the physical harm, a single colour brings little pleasure. **אבל כשימזגו קצתם בקצתם**: when colours are mixed, new kinds of pleasure arise and the faculties of the soul are greatly stirred. Saadia gives examples drawn from the medieval theory of the four humours:

Combination of colours (as the Rabbi read them)	What it arouses
Red mixed with yellow or green	The red bile: strength and courage
Yellow mixed with black	The white phlegm: lowliness and humility
Black, white, yellow and red together	The blood: the power of kingship and dominion
Yellow mixed with yellowish-green	The black bile: timidity and fear

As the proportions change, different forces are aroused in the soul. "I haven't checked each one of these whether they are scientifically correct or not... you can do that in your own time." The main point, he said, is one we can accept: individual colours are not as beautiful as a harmony of colours. "If that applies to colours and taste, all the more so for our characters."

What we see affects us

A participant, AB, added a Ramban. In Parashat Vayetze, Yaakov, working as Lavan's shepherd after the fourteen years, had the flock mate while looking at the striped rods, and the offspring came out spotted. The Ramban learns from this that what a person thinks about during intimacy affects the child. "So you see that your sight arouses different kinds of feelings within a person," and so too combinations of colours arouse different things in a person.

Hearing: music

וכן הקול הנפרד והנעימה הנפרדת... אבל המזג...

The same is true of hearing. A single sound or a single rhythm, repeated, does little for the soul, "what we call monotonous," and can even be bad for you. But a blend of sounds arouses its traits and powers in balance.

Then comes a technical passage. "Okay, I have no idea what this paragraph means. I'm going to read through it with the English. Anyone here understands music properly, you can help."

There are eight rhythms. Someone in the room connected this to **למנצח על השמינית**, the heading of a psalm, and another recalled learning that it refers to the eight notes of a scale. "Okay, very interesting."

Saadia describes each rhythm in terms of beats that are moving or resting and the intervals between them, and the humour each one arouses. The Rabbi read them with the English:

Rhythm	Pattern (from the translation)	Effect
1	Three beats: two consecutive, one quiescent	With the second: the blood, and the power of kingship and dominion
2	Three beats, one quiescent and one moving	(as above)
3	Two consecutive beats with no interval, then a resting beat, with a pause between rising and falling	The red bile: courage and strength of heart
4	Three consecutive beats with no interval, then a gap after every three	The phlegm: lowliness, submission and timidity
5 to 8	Various combinations of single and paired beats with intervals between them	The black bile: traits that move a person to joy or to worry

"As I said, I have no idea what this means. Maybe someone who's an expert in music would be able to explain this paragraph."

What struck the Rabbi was Saadia's range. "I think it's just incredible... his expertise in so many different fields," whether in astrology, the science of the creation of the universe, his mathematical discussions and his treatment of atoms. "So here he's showing us his expertise in music."

Why kings mix the rhythms

ומנהג המלכים למזוג קצתם בקצתם... ולא יצא לרבוי ברחמים ובאכזריות, ולא בגבורה ולא במורך, ולא בתוספת ובחסרון בשמחה

The practice of kings is to blend the rhythms so that what they arouse fits what is needed for governing: not too much mercy and not too much cruelty, not too much courage and not too much cowardice, not too much joy and not too little. The Rabbi: different music at different times. "When you're feeling down you play something upbeat; when you're feeling too happy... you play something a bit more low."

Think of an orchestra, he added. "The mixture of the violin with the piano with the flute, that causes the soul really to awaken. So you see the combination, how important it is."

Smell: perfumes

ועל זה הענין הריח הנפרד, לכל מריח ממנו כח, וכאשר ימזגו קצתם בקצתם...

Each scent has its own property, and blending them gives something new.

Scent	Property
Musk (*mor dror*)	Hot and dry
Camphor	Cold and delicate
Saffron	Hot and dry
Sandalwood (*ahalot*)	Cold and moist
Amber	Moderately warm
Rose water	Cold and delicate

When they are combined, their powers blend and become pleasing.

The point of it all

וכיון שההשואה בכל המוחשים יתר מעלה לאדם, כל שכן השוית מדותיו ואהבותיו שתהא מעולה לו יותר

"The final sentence, the most important sentence." If balance in every sense is so much better for a person, how much more so the balance of his traits and loves. Saadia takes examples from the physical world to show that spiritually and emotionally too, the best person combines different things.

"That's why it's never good to be extreme in anything." The Rabbi returned to *kana'ut*, zealotry, which "is not necessarily something which we promote." Only in very particular situations is it accepted. Even Pinchas: "once he did it, it was the right thing, but if he was to have come to ask should he have done this, he may have been told no."

Chapter 19: The Conclusion

The summary of the essay

והעולה מן הכלל הזה, שאדם קונה בעולם הזה כפי תקונו, ויאכל וישתה בהיתר כפי צרכו, וישים השגחתו על החכמה והעבודה והשם הטוב

The upshot: a person should acquire in this world what he needs, eat and drink what is permitted according to his need, and set his attention on wisdom, service of Hashem and a good name. From each of the thirteen he takes what is appropriate, everything in its time. **וזאת תהיה הבחירה המשובחת**.

On eating, the Rabbi said, "This is probably the best diet advice you could get." He returned to the Rambam in Hilchot Deot, which the class learned some years ago, that most medical problems come from overeating. "People go to the gym and they want to exercise; at the end of the day... it comes down essentially to what a person brings into their body."

Three verses from Kohelet

Saadia shows that Shlomo HaMelech said the same in three verses.

Verse 1. אין טוב באדם שיאכל ושתה והראה את נפשו טוב בעמלו, גם זה ראיתי אני כי מיד האלקים היא.

Words	What they include
שיאכל ושתה	Food and drink
בעמלו	Work, to earn money
מיד האלקים	What is permitted, what the Creator has graciously given, **לא מה שהוא חומס וגוזל**, not what is taken by force or robbery
טוב	Seven good things, explained below

This is where *perishut* comes in: stop when you have eaten and drunk enough, and stop when you are tempted to make money the wrong way.

Verse 2. וגם כל האדם שיאכל ושתה וראה טוב בכל עמלו, מתת אלקים היא. The same four elements: food, earning, the boundary of "a gift of God," and good.

Verse 3. הנה אשר ראיתי אני טוב אשר יפה לאכול ולשתות ולראות טובה בכל עמלו... כי הוא חלקו. The same four, and Saadia notes it adds **אשר יפה**, "which is fitting." That means each trait should be used at its proper time and not at another, as the same book says, **את הכל עשה יפה בעתו**. "That's how Hashem created the world, with its correct boundaries."

Three kinds of *tovah*: wisdom

The word **טובה** appears with wisdom in three verses, and each points to a different kind:

Verse	Saadia's explanation	Proof from the end of the verse
טובה חכמה עם נחלה	The wisdom of nature and the creation of the world, the sciences	**ויתר לראי השמש**: it speaks of what is under the sun
טובה חכמה מגבורה	Wisdom relating to the rank of kingship	The parable of the small city besieged by a great king
טובה חכמה מכלי קרב	Wisdom relating to service of Hashem	**וחוטא אחד יאבד טובה הרבה**: one sin destroys much good, so these are spiritual weapons

Seven kinds of *tov* in Kohelet

#	The good	Verse
1	**A good name and reputation**	**טוב שם משמן טוב**
2	**Remembering death** when the time comes, and not forgetting it	**טוב ללכת אל בית אבל מלכת אל בית משתה**
3	**Anger for the honour of the Creator**	**טוב כעס משחוק**
4	**Seeing the end of things**	**טוב אחרית דבר מראשיתו**
5	**Patience**	**טוב ארך רוח מגבה רוח**
6	**The company of the wise and righteous**	**טוב לשמע גערת חכם**
7	**Believing one is not immune from sin**, so as to be humble before Hashem	**טוב אשר תאחז בזה וגם מזה אל תנח ידך**

On the third, the Rabbi explained that it cannot mean real anger, "because anger is not allowed." *Ka'as* here means standing up and being insistent about what is right. On the fourth: "don't just look at the beginning, look at the end, look at the consequence." On the sixth: listen to the Chacham "even if he's telling you something which you don't like." On the seventh: "never overestimate your ability not to sin"; we are fragile, spiritually and not just physically.

Eleven things

רמז אלו הי"א דברים

Shlomo HaMelech, examining the affairs of the world, hinted at eleven things: seven he called **טוב**, three he called **טובה**, and one he called **יפה**, each thing in its right balance. Put together with eating, drinking and earning a living within boundaries, these give a person the good life. They come to a person when he lives the balanced life.

The purpose of the whole book

כי כל הספר איננו מועיל כי אם לזכות הלב וכוונת תיקונו

Saadia ends: the entire book is of benefit only for the purification of the heart and the intention to improve it, the refinement of a person's character and the focus to keep bettering himself throughout life. **אם אתה הכינות לבך**, and David's words, **בכל לבי דרשתיך... בלבי צפנתי אמרתך**. May our hearts be purified and humbled before Hashem, as it says, **יען רך לבבך ותכנע מפני ה'**.

כי הנאכל והנשתה והנראה והנשמע, עושים עם כונת הלב יותר ממה שעושים בלעדיה

What is eaten, drunk, seen and heard has a greater effect when the heart is focused on it. The Rabbi called it "a bit of mindfulness here as well." It is another reason people overeat: they don't focus when they are eating. "If you focus when you eat, then you eat what you need, because you take the real pleasure out of it." So too, focusing on *avodat Hashem* makes a person far more successful.

Saadia's closing prayer:

ואשאל מהאל יתברך ישימנו בין המאמינים ולא מן התועים, וישים בלבנו אהבתו ויראתו, כדי שנזכה לחיי העולם הזה ולחיי העולם הבא

May Hashem place us among the believers and not among those who go astray, and put His love and His fear in our hearts, so that we merit the life of this world and the life of the World to Come.

תם ונשלם ספר אמונות ודעות, תהלות לאל מגלה צפונות

"Praise to God who reveals the secrets. Chazak u'baruch."

The Siyum and What Comes Next

The class began the sefer on **22 January 2024**, so it took exactly two years. Saadia, the Rabbi recalled, was the very first to write Jewish theology in a structured way. Next week he would go through his notes and draw out ten to fifteen main takeaways from the ten essays, and in a couple of weeks start a new sefer.

Over the last six or seven years the class has learned the Ramchal's Derech Hashem and Da'at Tevunot, and now Emunot VeDeot. The three options he was considering:

Option	The Rabbi's description
The Moreh Nevuchim (the Rambam's Guide for the Perplexed)	Will take a long time and needs consistency; "not really something you can dip in and out of." Some parts are quite esoteric and hard to comprehend. "The most challenging but equally, I believe, the most rewarding."
HaMaspik l'Ovdei Hashem by **Rabbeinu Avraham ben HaRambam**	Written in Arabic as *al-Kifayah*, "what is sufficient" to serve Hashem. First translated into Hebrew only in 1965, by Rabbi Sassoon, in honour of the wedding of his son-in-law, Rabbi Gabbay of Ohel David, where the translation was given out. Feldheim later published an English translation based on it. "I wouldn't call it a musar book... but it's more towards musar," and the parts he had seen were thought-provoking. He had never learned it properly, "so this would be a nice opportunity to study together."
The Kuzari of Rabbi Yehudah HaLevi	A dialogue, like Da'at Tevunot, with "a more mystical framework," quite different from the Rambam and Emunot VeDeot

He invited preferences from everyone, in the room and on Zoom.

Summary

1. **Harmony is a principle of all creation,** not only of character. Saadia shows it in the senses.
2. **Touch and taste:** softness pleases; mixed dishes taste best.
3. **Sight:** a single colour tires and even harms the eye (snow blindness); blends of colours arouse different powers in the soul.
4. **Hearing:** eight rhythms, each stirring a different humour. Kings blend them to avoid excess mercy or cruelty, courage or cowardice. Think of an orchestra.
5. **Smell:** perfumes of different natures blend into something pleasing.
6. **Therefore** the balance of one's traits is all the more valuable. Zealotry is generally not the Jewish way.

7. **Chapter 19:** acquire what you need, eat and drink what is permitted as you need, and give your attention to wisdom, service of Hashem and a good name. Kohelet hints at eleven goods: seven *tov*, three *tovah*, one *yafeh*.
8. **The purpose of the whole book** is the refinement of the heart. What we do with focus affects us more. *Chazak u'baruch.*

Coming Up

- **Next week:** the key takeaways from the whole of Emunot VeDeot.
- **In a couple of weeks:** the new Monday sefer, chosen from the Moreh Nevuchim, HaMaspik and the Kuzari.

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